



JOHN HORNER FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

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Light touch works wonders at Diva Lounge

Husband-and-wife team stresses illumination in inventive restaurant interior

By Robert Campbell

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SOMERVILLE — Young architects often get started by designing restaurants.

A restaurant interior is a kind of stage set. In a good one, the customer feels special — a bit, for the moment, like a star.

Like a set, too, a restaurant interior usually isn't going to last forever. The architect can take some chances, can try out fresh, maybe daring ideas, all at relatively low cost and low risk.

Such a place recently opened in Davis Square. It's the Diva Lounge at 248 Elm St., a couple of blocks from the T stop. This is the most delightful, most inventive space of its kind we've seen in years.

The architects are a married couple in their early 30s, Hansy Barraza and Anthony Piermarini. They're an example of today's global culture: Barraza comes originally from Colombia, Piermarini is from Leominster, and they met at Cornell before moving on to the Harvard Design School.

They call their firm Studio Luz, from the Spanish word for light. They try to design with light. At the Diva, they've pulled it off. You feel wrapped in a puffy quilt of il-

lumination. Walls and ceilings are surfaced with a skin of luminous shapes that look like glass pillows. They radiate a warm orange-pink color. They seem to blush and billow, like sails in the sunset. Light levels can be adjusted to set different moods at different times.

"We wanted to make it feel ephemeral, illuminated, singular — something very other from what you're used to," says Piermarini. "Upscale but not pretentious." The owner is Amrik Pabla, who has half a dozen Boston restaurants. The lounge is an adjunct to his earlier Diva restaurant next door. Globalization again: The lounge's cuisine, says Barraza, is "Indian tapas." "We wanted a Bollywood feeling," adds Piermarini.

As with any good architecture, the metaphors are varied. You can think of the pillow-like walls as a padded cell, where you're safe from harming yourself. Or if you're of a certain age, you can see the lights as a multicolored Chiclet-lined candy store.

Barraza and Piermarini are not shy about their own merits. Barraza says Studio Luz is one of a few good firms of young architects in Boston. ("There are zillions in New York," she adds, but she and

Piermarini prefer the calmer pace of Boston.)

Like many young architects, both partners teach to make ends meet. Barraza is a tenured associate professor at the Rhode Island School of Design, where Piermarini also teaches. They've designed two other restaurants in Boston, Seijo and Kashmir, and a third, to be called Mela, will open soon.

Besides being delightful to be in, Diva Lounge also gives you the pleasure of a kind of trivia game. The game is to figure out where the materials and details come from. Those glassy pillow lights? The manufacturer never imagined they'd be used as lights. They are plastic replacement domes for skylights. There are 540 of them. Behind the bar, the domes are turned backward to make a different kind of glassy surface.

And the rough dark wood at the bar and in the banquettes? It's butternut, and if you look close, you'll see it's full of wormholes. It is salvage wood from Vermont. Piermarini notes that without the Internet, it would have been hard to find. "You just Google 'rustic wood' or 'reclaimed wood' or something like that," he says. The rough old wood makes a foil for

the smooth plastic domes. They're like a grandfather and a baby, cheek to cheek.

Look closely at the banquettes. The wooden backs are shaped with openings. "It's so customers sitting back-to-back will rub shoulders," says Piermarini. "We wanted the architecture to spark social encounters."

There's a history to Studio Luz's fascination with materials. Before the partners started their own firm, Piermarini worked for Kennedy & Violich, a firm that is constantly experimenting with new materials and new uses for old ones. Barraza worked for the Boston firm Office d'A, which designed the amazing restaurant Mantra, another feast of light and materials, although with a very different mood. Mantra's downstairs cocktail lounge, the OmBar, is a Studio Luz addition.

Before you leave Diva Lounge, don't miss the yurt-like toilet pods. Try to figure out exactly what is being pictured in the sexy red images, inspired by the Kama Sutra, that adorn their doors.

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